

Caretakers Fruits and Vegetables Shopping Patterns: A Community-Based Pilot Study to Strengthen Farmers Markets Benefits Use among Overweight/Obese children ages 2-5 years Participating in the City of Hartford Women, Infant, and Children (WIC) Program

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BACKGROUND

- By December 2023, Hartford WIC program had 5,689 active clients. Low-income children, between the ages of 2 and 5 were overweight (15.2%) and obese (17,5%) (1).
- Both financial access and geographic access to healthy foods are important determinants of fruits and vegetables (F&V) consumption (2).

OBJECTIVES

This study will document F&V shopping patterns and barriers to purchasing F&V.

METHODS

Design. Cross-sectional study, secondary data/sub-study. A community-based participatory research between UConn Health and the Hartford WIC program*.

Setting and sample

- *Inclusion Criteria:* Parents or caregivers of children between the ages of 2 and 5; child currently receiving WIC benefits; (Child BMI-for-age > 85th percentile, based on the CDC growth charts); Hartford area residents; read and write in Spanish or English; Being the main shopper/person who prepares the foods for the child.
- *Exclusion Criteria:* not having access to a cell phone/android, tablet or computer with an unlimited data plan for the purpose of completing the on-line surveys.

Measures:

- Socio-economic and demographic characteristics
- Fruit and vegetables shopping patterns & obstacles

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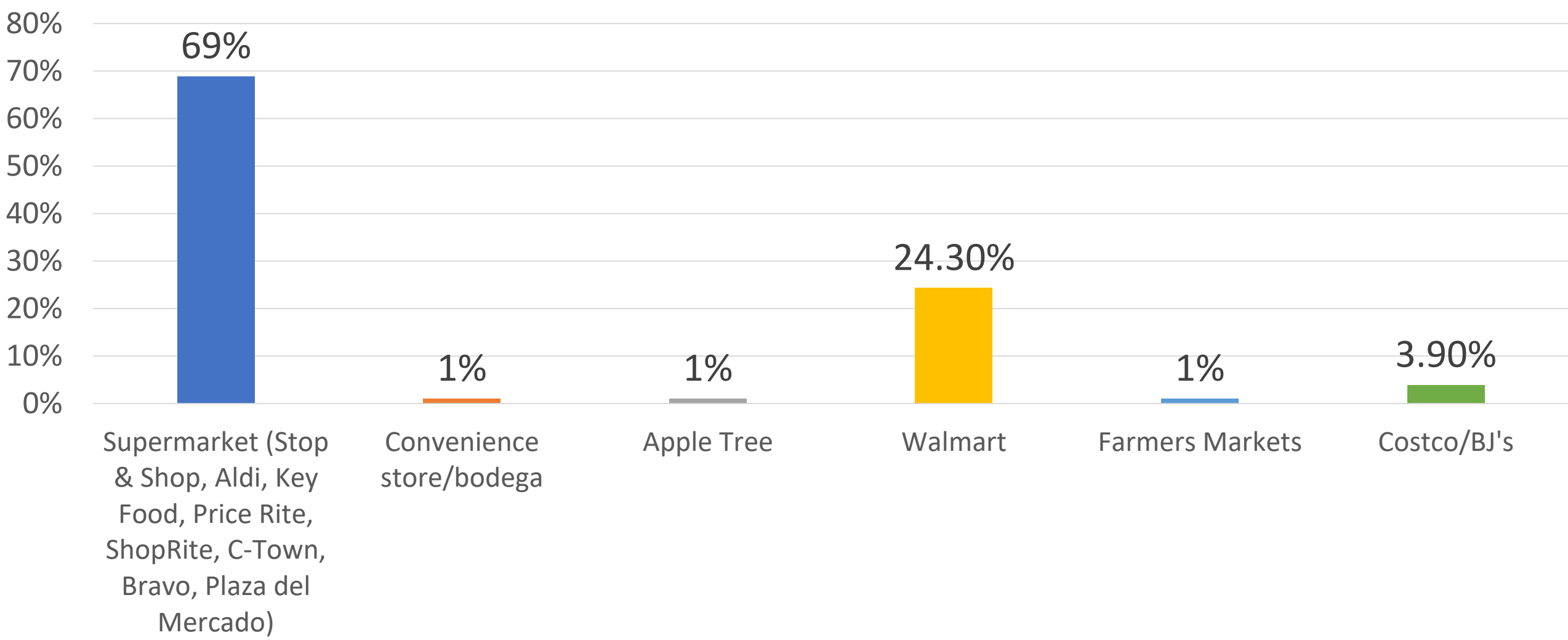
RESULTS

37.9% of the children were overweight and 62.1% were in the obese categories (based on the CDC growth charts).

Table 1. Sample Characteristics ¹	
Characteristics	Total ¹
Age, Mean ± SD	32 ± 7
Gender	
Female	105 (99.1)
Education (%)	
Some high school or less	24 (23.1)
High school or GED	28 (26.9)
Some college	26 (25.0)
Associates or college	23 (22.1)
Marital Status (%)	
Living with a spouse or partner	34 (36.2)
Not living with a spouse or partner	60 (63.8)
Monthly Income (%)	
Below \$2000	61 (58.1)
More than \$2001	25 (23.8)
Refused/Unknown	19 (18.1)
Employment Status (%)	
Employed	50 (49.5)
Unemployed	51 (50.5)
Race (%)	
Non-Hispanics Whites	4 (3.8)
Blacks/African Americans	37 (35.2)
Hispanics	60 (57.1)
Others (Asians, American Indian, etc.)	4 (3.8)

Values are presented either in means ± SDs or n (%). ¹ Note. Sample size may be off, due to missing data/don't know/refused answers, no more than 5% of data was missing.

Figure 1. Where do you usually buy your fruits and vegetables?



Among the 67% of participants reporting receiving vouchers from WIC to use at the local farmers market, only 81% used them.

Table 1. Selected Reported Obstacles to Purchasing Fruits and Vegetables at the Local Farmers Markets

Obstacle	% reporting obstacle
Price	27.8
Time	23.1
Unknown location	41.9
Fruit and vegetables child eat is/are not available	22.0
Transportation	25.0

Conclusions

- This study fruit and vegetable (F&V) purchasing behaviors among caregivers in the Hartford WIC program-
- Participants report obstacles to farmer's market use & fruit/vegetable consumption.
- Future interventions should identify and address participants barriers to improve F&V through WIC benefits.

References

1. Khouy, P. Hartford WIC office overweight and obesity rates, 2023
2. Evans A, Banks K, Jennings R, Nehme E, Nemec C, Sharma S, et al. Increasing access to healthful foods: a qualitative study with residents of low-income communities. Int J Behav Nutr Phys Act. 2015 Dec;12(S1):S5.